

many states offer free community college programs to their residents, especially those who demonstrate financial need.¹⁷ Over a couple of years, you can easily save tens of thousands of dollars in student loan debt.

They give you a chance to see if college is right for you. As noted above, if you're undecided, attending community college provides an opportunity to experience higher education without breaking your bank. Many students worry that they will choose a major only to later find out they hate it. If this describes you, why would you want to be paying tons of money while you are figuring this out? Going to a community college for a few years can help you to find out which classes you really enjoy.

They can be a good way to transition to a four-year school. Some community colleges have partnerships with four-year universities to create a smooth transition between schools by ensuring your credits from community college will transfer to a four-year institution. This benefit helps students complete their bachelor's degree in four years.

They offer an authentic college experience. Many of my students say they do not want to attend a community college because they want a more traditional college experience. However, like four-year universities, most community colleges offer extracurricular clubs and have sports teams—and many are offering on-campus housing at an increasing rate.¹⁸ You can still make friends, go to parties, and paint your face as a member of

17 Inder Singh Bisht, "Is Community College Free? In These States, Yes," *The College Post*, last modified October 23, 2020, <https://thecollegepost.com/free-community-college-states>.

18 Kate Barrington, "The Pros and Cons of On-Campus Housing for Community College," *Community College Review*, last modified May 22, 2020, <https://www.communitycollegereview.com/blog/the-pros-and-cons-of-on-campus-housing-for-community-college>.